

Prairie Dropseed

Sporobolus heterolepis

Northern Prairie Dropseed



QUALITIES

A fine-textured warm-season bunchgrass forming a graceful arching mound 2 to 3 feet tall and equally wide. Hair-thin medium-green leaves give it the softest texture of any prairie grass. Airy panicles of tiny seeds appear in August, releasing a mild buttered-popcorn or coriander fragrance that surprises first-time visitors. Foliage turns golden bronze in fall.

CARE

Full sun is essential; tolerates almost any soil including clay. Drought-tolerant once established but appreciates occasional summer water. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Slow to establish (3-year root development); plant from 1-gallon stock for fastest results. Long-lived once settled — an undisturbed clump can persist for decades. Cut to 6 inches in late winter.

HISTORY

Prairie dropseed was a co-dominant grass of the drier-mesic prairies of southern Minnesota and was a Dakota food plant — the seeds, parched and ground, were used as flour. Following the conversion of prairies to agriculture, dropseed retreated to remnant sites; it is now a flagship indicator species for prairie restoration quality. Its slow establishment and refusal to transplant easily make it a marker of patient gardeners and undisturbed soil.

REASON TO BE

Prairie dropseed is the front-edge grass of choice for any bed that meets a path or a lawn. Its fountain form softens edges; its fine texture contrasts beautifully with broad-leaved forbs; and the late-summer popcorn scent is one of the small joys of native gardening that no garden-design book ever mentions. Native bees and skippers use the foliage; goldfinches harvest the seed.